MCP

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Hashtag

by Steve DuBois

[Backstage at VidCon. MEGAN is a teenage internet personality: attractive, poised, and capable of being, at the drop of a hat, whomever her fans want her to be. Her social media account ManyManyMegans has introduced millions of fans to her and to her split personalities. NANCY is a fangirl. About the same age as Megan, she is carrying a few extra pounds, a tote bag, and a whole lot of invisible baggage.]

NANCY: Megan?

MEGAN: Yes?

NANCY: Megan! Oh my God, it's YOU! Hashtag ManyManyMegans!

MEGAN: It's…me!

NANCY: Oh my God, you are totally my favorite multiple personality account. I've followed them all…the Brittany System, Adeline And Friends, even Group-O-Gretchens. But you are the BEST. I'm Nancy, by the way.

MEGAN: Oh, thank you…Nancy. Um…how did you…

NANCY: Your alters…oh. my. God. I mean, they've all…they've all been through so much. You've all of you been *so brave*. I mean, Candice, with her Tourettes…hi, Candice!

[Megan's posture shifts slightly, and she adopts a facial tic. Each of her "alters" displays an obvious physical distinction from the others. It is, for lack of a better word, "interpy".]

MEGAN: Hi there!

NANCY: And Amy, with her eating disorder…

MEGAN: Uh…hello. How did you…

NANCY: And Mags, the oppositional-defiant one! "The girl who puts the 'dis' in 'disassociative identity disorder'"!

MEGAN: Yo!

NANCY: And Betty. Betty's my favorite! Bipolar Betty.

MEGAN: How did you get backstage?

NANCY: Huh?

MEGAN: I mean…don't get me wrong, it's always great to meet a fan, especially one who's so…dedicated. Look, I'll be signing later in the main ballroom, and…*we'd all* be thrilled to talk to you then.

NANCY: Oh, yeah, that'd be great! The life of a social media star, right? Hashtag SoBusy… But I wanted to talk privately for a little while.

MEGAN: Okay. Uh, look. There's a time and place, and I don't normally…

[Nancy calmly reaches into her tote bag, and withdraws a pistol.]

NANCY: I think you will, though.

MEGAN: Okay. Okay.

NANCY: So I'd like to talk to Meredith.

MEGAN: Listen. I, uh…I can't just, you know, call up my alters on command…

NANCY: That's weird. Because every time you need them for a video, they just sort of *show up*, in a little parade. So, let's, like, pretend, okay. Let's pretend you're doing one of your little shows. Where your "alters" do tricks like dolphins at Sea World.

MEGAN: That's not…

NANCY: Meredith. I want to talk to Meredith, please. *Right now.*

MEGAN: *[shifting to another alter]* This…is Meredith speaking.

NANCY: Hi, Meredith! Hashtag BigFan. You're so smart. What was your IQ again?

MEGAN: Well…IQ…um…Intelligence Quotient isn't a constant. It varies depending on the test that's used to measure it. But utilizing the Wechsler test, my IQ has been measured at one hundred and seventy seven.

NANCY: That's very smart. What does "gentrification" mean?

MEGAN: Look, I think you misunderstand. IQ is a test of intellectual potential, not of vocabulary…

NANCY: Let me help you. Gentrification is the process by which new people, usually rich people, move into a place. And they push out the people who already live there.

MEGAN: Okay. Nancy…

NANCY: It's usually used for, like, a neighborhood. Where poor people live, and the bougies move in. But it's, like, also something that happens in other ways.

MEGAN: Nancy, look…

NANCY: Like…let's say you've got a mental health condition, okay? And let's say this condition *really sucks*.

MEGAN: Nancy…

NANCY: And you're, like, on these pills for it. And they just vaporize you. Like, when you take them, you stop being a person.

MEGAN: Nancy, you…you need to know this…

NANCY: And you also gain, like, thirty pounds. And you get the worst acne ever. And the alternative is, you *don't* take the pills, and your brain turns into, like, a *catapult*. Like, it launches you into the sky, and then it drops you into the bottomless pit! Over and over again! And whether you take the pills or don't take them, *you are one hot mess of a human being!*

MEGAN: Nancy, my alters…

NANCY: And then, on one of those rare days when you're functional, you go online. And there's this *girl* there. And she's got perfect hair, and perfect skin. Oh, but she's *mentally ill,* she says! And she's turned it into her goddamn *gimmick*!

MEGAN: Nancy, please! I'm not actually…my alters…these are just *characters* I play*…*

NANCY: *DO YOU THINK I DON'T KNOW THAT? DO YOU HONESTLY THINK WE DON'T ALL KNOW THAT?* This girl…she's got the perfect life! And it's not enough! She has to have yours, too! She can't just be better than you in every other way, *she has to suffer more, too! This bitch is gentrifying your life!*

MEGAN: Nancy…

NANCY: This…*trauma porn*…I mean…it's like it's a competition! It's like, "she who suffers most wins!" And it's SICK. You're the smart one, "Meredith," so you tell me.

[She raises the gun and points it straight at Megan's face]

NANCY: How would you expect a person who's actually suffering from mental illness to react to this *performance*?

MEGAN: She'd be furious. She'd have every right to be. *[pause]* And she'd have no bullets in her gun.

NANCY: WHAT?

MEGAN: You've suffered, Nancy, and I'm so sorry. You're hurting. But you're not a hurter.

NANCY: DON'T TURN ME INTO A MASCOT! STAY IN YOUR GODDAMN LANE! YOU DON'T HAVE ANY IDEA WHAT IT'S LIKE!

MEGAN: You're right. I don't. I'm not bipolar. But, Nancy…you're not *only* bipolar. It's not who you are, it's a condition you have. If you wanted to hurt me, you'd have already done it. You wanted to teach me. So, yes, I hear you. But that gun's empty.

[The gun in Nancy's hand shakes, and she dissolves in tears. Megan draws a long, shuddering breath. She reaches out, and gently removes the gun from Nancy's grasp. She looks at it.]

MEGAN: This is a water pistol, Nancy.

NANCY: *[Through her sobs]* I'm sorry. I just…had to hear you say it. I had to hear you admit you were a fraud.

MEGAN: It's…a very realistic water pistol.

NANCY: Yeah, you'd know fake, wouldn't you?

MEGAN: It's not all fake.

NANCY: Oh, *please*.

MEGAN: Amy's real.

NANCY: What?

MEGAN: Amy's the real me. Megan's fake.

NANCY: Wait…so…you've actually got an eating disorder?

MEGAN: I've had one. My doctor and I…we eventually decided that I was spending too much time looking in the mirror, searching for flaws. We decided that I needed to appreciate that everybody's got their own flaws and their own monsters. So I…decided to explore what it would be like to be other people.

NANCY: You stole other people's pain, you mean.

MEGAN: It's not like that! Okay, maybe it is like that, a little. But what you're calling "stealing"…I call it empathy. I'm very good at empathy, Nancy. It's how I knew you weren't actually here to hurt me. And no, I can't fully know anybody else's *specific* pain. But I can understand what it is to be *in* pain. And people can't just…what was it you said? We can't just "stay in our lanes" forever. We have to try to reach outside of ourselves, and imagine–even imperfectly–what it's like to be someone else. I spent sixteen months inspecting myself in the mirror, Nancy. A life spent examining yourself is no life at all.

NANCY: But you take it way, *way* too far. I mean, why do you *do* this?

MEGAN: Well…that thing you said about "trauma porn"…you're probably right about that. On the internet, you have to get attention to make money. And it's like you said: "she who suffers

the most, wins." It's a sick game. But I need the money. Everybody's gotta eat. *[pause]* Especially Amy.

NANCY: You seriously think it's OK to *joke* about that?

MEGAN: Well, as a smart girl once said, "I'm one hot mess of a human being."

NANCY: At least you're not going to jail.

MEGAN: I think maybe nobody is.

NANCY: Wait, what? You're not serious.

MEGAN: Look.This has sucked in a major way. But you're not wrong. This thing I'm doing…it's not all right. I can't create empathy by pretending to be someone I'm not. Let alone several people I'm not. Hashtag ScaredStraight. I won't rat you out.

NANCY: Oh, wow. Oh, oh, oh wow. Oh. My. God. Thank you. Thank you so much.

MEGAN: Nancy. Take those pills. I mean it.

NANCY: I will. Oh my God. Megan…Amy…if your fans could see this. They'd never need to see the alters again. Whoever you are…you're enough.

MEGAN: That's…wow. *Wow*. I think I've been needing to hear someone say that. Thank you.

NANCY: Hashtag BestFriends?

MEGAN: Well, let's not get ahead of ourselves. But…you'll be at the signing, right?

NANCY: It's a date!

MEGAN: Just leave the squirt gun at home.

NANCY: Deal!